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VOL. I.

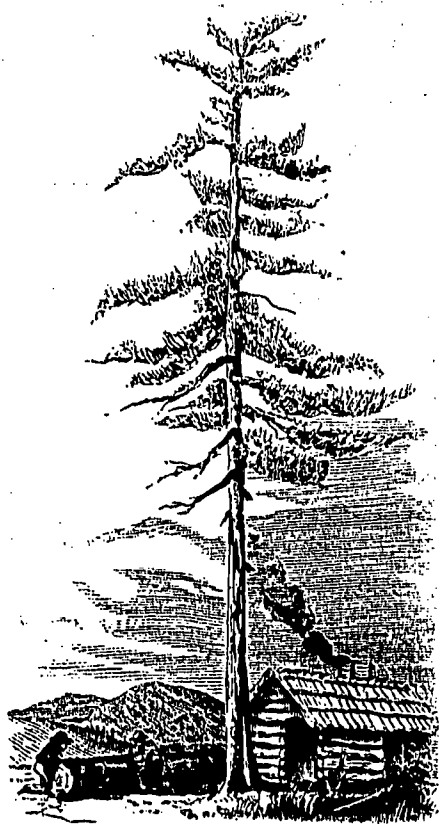
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NO. V.

MOUNTAIN SCENERY IN CALIFORNIA.

There is a wild, bold, and beautiful magnificence in the mountain scenery of California, that strikes the mind of those who look upon it for the first time, with feelings of delight and awe. Its pine-crested hills; its deep mountain-gorges; its towering and rugged cliffs; its dark and densely-timbered forests; its impetuous and foaming cataracts; its rolling and surging streams; its deep and shadowy cañons; its cabin-dotted and miner-tenanted ravines; its populous and busy mining towns; with all the diversified landscape of hill and dale, and all the variety of active mining life, and difference in method of living and working; that, while it pleases by its novelty, interests and charms by its mystery and singularity.

It is our pleasing task, this month, to place before the reader some of those scenes, and to give a brief sketch of each engraving. Commencing with



A MINER'S CABIN, NEAR PINE GROVE, SIERRA COUNTY.

There is a peculiarity in the construction and appearance of cabins in

**NARRATIVE OF A WOMAN WHO
WAS EIGHTEEN YEARS ALONE,
UPON THE ISLAND OF SAN NIC-
OLAS, COAST OF CALIFORNIA.**

MR. EDITOR:—It is with pleasure that I have seen your efforts to rescue from oblivion, and perpetuate in your Magazine, the many wonderful things that relate to the early history of our State. During a residence of eight years upon this coast, in which time I have explored over eighteen hundred miles of it, I have been enabled to treasure up many things in my journal which may be of interest to your many readers; I shall take pleasure in occasionally giving you an extract from it, and, as there is no time like the present, I will commence with the following:

Alexander Selkirk, the hero of Defoe's enchanting story of Robinson Crusoe, was only four years upon the desert island of Juan Fernandez. Could we but find an author at the present day, with Defoe's graphic imagination, we believe sufficient facts of the lonely exile of this woman for eighteen years, could be obtained to make one of the most thrilling and beautifully descriptive volumes ever published.

Those who are acquainted with the geography of this coast, will remember that about two hundred and fifty miles south of San Francisco, a chain of islands commences, called the Santa Barbara Islands. While stationed upon one of this group—the island of San Miguel—making tidal observations for the U. S. Government, I was visited by Mr. George Nediver, an old resident of California, who came over from the main land, on a hunting excursion, and encamped beside me, and from whom I

obtained much valuable information concerning the early history of these islands, as well as the adjacent coast.

One evening, while seated beside our quiet camp-fire, placidly smoking our pipes, Mr. N. related to me the following remarkable history:

Twenty years ago, the whole of the Indian tribes inhabiting this group of islands were engaged in a fierce and exterminating war with each other, and to such an extent was this deadly hostility waged that already the population had very much diminished, and would, in all probability, before many years, become entirely extinct. To prevent this, and at the same time to ameliorate the condition of the Indians, the good Fathers of the Mission of Santa Barbara conceived the idea of removing them to the main land, where they might be watched over, improved, and preserved, under their immediate superintendence.

For this purpose they visited the islands, in company with a few partially civilized Indians, and explained to them the advantages of removing to the Mission. They listened attentively to the proposal, and finally consented to go, on promises of protection from their natural enemies being given by the Fathers.

Accordingly a small vessel was sent to the different islands, and the various tribes were taken one by one, to the Mission of Santa Barbara. But while the last of the Indians were embarking, at the island of San Nicolas, and all were supposed to be on board, a child was missing, and its mother, in great distress was seeking everywhere, without success; each portion of the vessel was diligently searched; all the adja-

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cent rocks were examined, but no child could be found. Almost frantic, the mother requested the Captain to wait while she went into the interior to search for her child, to which he reluctantly consented.

As night closed down in darkness, heavy masses of clouds rolled up from the horizon, and gave threatening evidence of a coming storm. All were anxious for the return of the woman and her child, before it broke upon them, but still they came not. The wind began to blow, harder and stronger; the storm was rapidly increasing; and as the groups of Indians on board strained their eyes, trying to discover, in the darkness, some object that resembled the returning woman and her child, yet saw them not, there were many sad hearts and anxious countenances that night, on their account.

The storm at last came on in all its fury, tossing their little vessel up and down like a feather, and compelled them at last, though reluctantly, to put to sea for safety, before any tidings of the absent ones could be received; and, although the cargo of living freight reached Santa Barbara in safety, before the vessel could return for the woman, it was wrecked and entirely lost; and as no other could be obtained at that time, the poor woman had to remain upon the island, where she lived, *alone*, for eighteen years; no doubt forgotten, or given up as long since dead.

After the discovery of gold, it was rumored that San Nicolas was inhabited, and this, no doubt, had its foundation in the fact that several hunters of the sea otter, had seen the print of human footsteps, and they endeavored to discover the whereabouts of the in-

dividuals, but could not: yet, as all the footprints were alike, they concluded that there could be only one person living upon it; and many attempts were made to find out who, and where this strange being was, but without avail, until one of California's oldest pioneers, Mr. Nediver—the gentleman who related to me the story, and who arrived in this country some twenty-five years ago, and still resides at Santa Barbara—went over to look for her, and who, having spent many years as a hunter, and trapper in the Rocky Mountains, was as expert as an Indian, in following a trail, and consequently found but little difficulty in discovering the track, which he followed until he saw a singular object among the rocks upon the sea shore, near the mouth of a ravine, upon its knees, engaged in skinning a seal. Upon approaching, he found it to be a woman clad in a singular dress of feathers; and, when she saw him, she jumped up, and with excessive joy ran towards him, and seemed almost beside herself with wild delight, at the sight, once more, of a human being.

In her hand she held a rude knife-blade, that she had made from a piece of old iron, probably obtained from the fragment of some wreck, and which she evidently valued beyond anything else in her possession.

She was unable to make herself understood, except by signs; in making which she showed a great amount of intelligence, and signified her willingness to accompany him to Santa Barbara. Here Father Gonzales, of the Mission, took the greatest pains to discover some of the Indians who had been taken from those islands, eighteen

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years before, but not one of them could be found, and what became of them, is a mystery unto this day. Not one of the Indians within a circumference of many miles, could be found, who could understand her. So that she could communicate only by signs.

It appears from her narrative, that after leaving the vessel in search of her child, she wandered about for several hours, and when she found it, the wild dogs which infest the island, even to the present day, had killed, and nearly devoured it. We can better imagine the feelings of a mother at such a time, than describe them. When she returned to the spot where she had left the vessel, to tell of her sorrows, for the loss of her child, that too was gone, and was bearing away her kindred and friends from her sight.

Could she have realized, then, that for eighteen long years she must live *alone* in the world, without one kind word of comfort, one cheering look from a friendly eye, or one smile of recognition, it would have been too much for even her wild, but womanly nature to bear, and with her, as with us, it is well that we know not the future.

From day to day, she lived in hope, beguiling the weary hours in providing for her wants. With snares made of her hair she caught birds; and with the skins, properly prepared, she made her clothing; her needles were neatly made of bone, and cactus thorns; her thread was of sinews from the seal: in these, and many other articles found in her possession, she exhibited much of the native ingenuity she possessed.

Whether she still remembered her own language or not, will forever remain a mystery. She was very gentle,

and kind, especially to children, and nothing seemed to please her more than to be near them: and the poor woman would often shed tears, while attempting to describe, by signs, her own little one which had been killed and eaten by the wild dogs.

The sympathy felt for her welfare, caused the people to supply her, bountifully, with everything she needed; and, very imprudently, allowed her to eat almost anything she chose, and the result was, that in about six months after her escape from her lonely exile she sickened and died—having, undoubtedly, been killed with kindness.

At the conclusion of the old gentleman's tale, I was more than ever convinced of the truthfulness of the remark, that "Truth is stranger than fiction."—C. J. W. RUSSELL.

IMMENSITY OF THE UNIVERSE.—

As a proof of what a vast book the visible heavens are, and also of the diligence of the student, man, in turning over its leaves, Dr. Nichol, in his work describing the magnitude of Lord Ross's telescope, says that Lord Ross has looked into space a distance so inconceivable, that light, which travels at the rate of 200,000 miles in one second, would require a period of 250,000,000 of solar years, each year containing about 32,000,000 of seconds, to pass the intervening gulf between this earth and the remotest point to which this telescope has reached. How utterly unable is the mind to grasp even a fraction of this immense period. To conceive the passing events of a hundred thousand years only, is an impossibility, to say nothing of millions and hundreds of millions of years.

Forget injuries and remember benefits. If you grant a favor, forget it; if you receive one, remember it.

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